Lesson 02: Dreams: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 1.1: Discussion; 1.2: Listening-Why Do We Dream?; 1.3: Reading-The Story Behind Dreams; 16.1: Chapter 1 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

You will think about your own dreams, watch a short TED-Ed talk about why we dream, and read the article "The Story Behind Dreams". You will practise finding the central idea, the supporting evidence and the author's purpose of a text, and you will learn the language that psychology texts use to report theories.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Follow a short academic talk that compares several theories, and answer detail questions about it.
- Find the central idea of an article and choose the quotation that best supports it.
- Explain the author's purpose and why the author includes a particular example.
- Report a theory with phrases such as "The theory holds that ..." and "Scientists believe that ...".
- Write a short discussion post about dreams and reply to other people's posts.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
theory	an idea that tries to explain something; it is not proven	A number of theories have emerged.
definitive	final and certain	One day we will discover the definitive reason for them.
recurring dream	a dream about the same topic that comes again and again	Do you have recurring dreams?
subconscious / unconscious mind	the part of the mind with thoughts and wishes that we are not aware of	Dreams relate to the fulfillment of our subconscious wishes.
prophecy (plural: prophecies)	a vision of the future	The ancient Greeks and Romans believed that dreams showed prophecies.
symbolic	standing for something else	Dreams also have symbolic meanings.
neocortex	the part of the brain that controls thoughts	Your neocortex reviews these neural connections.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
hippocampus	the part of the brain that controls memory	Scientists found bursts of electricity in the hippocampus.
consolidate	make stronger and longer-lasting (here: memories)	Your brain needs to consolidate and create long-term memories.
rehearse	practise before the real event	We dream to rehearse.
inspiration	a sudden idea for something new or creative	Dreams have long been considered sources for inspiration.
hazy	not clear	What we know for sure is still as hazy as dreams often are.
central idea	the most important point of a whole text	Which statement best expresses the central idea of the text?
author's purpose	the reason the author wrote the text (to explore, inform, prove, criticize ...)	What is the author's main purpose in the text?

Rules and explanations

How the talk is organized

- The talk "Why Do We Dream?" starts with a short history (Mesopotamian kings, an Ancient Egyptian dream book). Then it presents one theory after another.
- Each theory begins with a short signpost sentence: "We dream to ...". Listen for these sentences. Write each one as a heading in your notes, then add the name of the theory and one study or example.

How the reading is organized

- Paragraphs 1-2: introduction (a dream story, then what people believed about dreams in history).
- "Why We Dream" (paragraphs 3-6): four ideas, each introduced with a signal phrase: "One idea is that ...", "Another theory says that ...", "More recent advancements suggest that ...", "However, some scientists still think that ...".
- "Benefits" (paragraphs 7-9): a study with a maze, then two famous examples.
- "Conclusions" (paragraph 10).
- Signal phrases like these tell you that the writer is moving to a new idea.

Questions about a whole text

- **Central idea (Part A):** the main point of the whole text, not one detail. Test each option: is it true for the whole text? Is every part of it in the text? An option with one false part is wrong.
- **Supporting detail (Part B):** choose the quotation that says the same thing as your Part A answer. Part A and Part B must match.

- **Author's purpose:** look at the verb in each option (explore, inform, prove, criticize, support) and ask: does the whole text do this, or only one paragraph?
- **"How does … contribute to the development of ideas?":** ask yourself why the author included this example. What point does it show?

Reporting a theory

The talk and the reading use these patterns. They are very common in psychology:

- A theory **holds that / proposes that / states that / says that** + clause: "The continual activation theory proposes that your dreams result from your brain's need to constantly consolidate and create long-term memories."
- People **believe / theorize / suggest / point out that** + clause: "Researchers theorize that certain memory processes can happen only when we are asleep."
- For ideas that are not proven, writers use **might, could, may**: "Dreams might allow people to get the sleep they need."

Grammar to notice (Lesson 03)

- Simple present for theories and facts: "Scientists believe that your brain might be preparing …"
- Simple past for history and finished studies: "The ancient Egyptians believed that dreams were messages from the gods."
- Present perfect for time up to now: "For much of human history, we've tried to make sense of them."

Practice

Before you start: read the discussion questions in the Writing task and think about your answers for two minutes.

Exercise 1. Listening comprehension. Watch "Why Do We Dream?" (see Watch online) first, without the transcript. Answer the questions. Then watch again. Read the transcript at the end of the lesson material only after you have answered.

1. Humans have discovered the definitive reason that we have dreams. a) True b) False
2. Known as The Father of Psychoanalysis, this doctor's theory of dreaming holds that the images in our dreams have symbolic meanings which relate to our subconscious wishes. a) Carl Jung b) Wilhelm Reich c) Sigmund Freud d) Hermann Rorschach e) Alfred Adler
3. The "Continuation Activation Theory" of dreams holds that you dream in order to: a) Keep your brain active when sensory input is low b) Figure out difficult problems from the day before c) All of the above d) Remember important things in the morning e) None of the above
4. Keeping your fight or flight instincts sharp is one of the reasons we dream, according to which theory? a) Continual Activation Theory b) Primitive Instinct Rehearsal Theory c) Reverse Learning Theory d) None of the above e) The Committee of Sleep Theory

5. According to the results of one research study, a person will be able to get through a 3D virtual maze the fastest on their second attempt at it if they: a) Take a nap but don't dream anything between their first and second attempts at getting through the 3D maze b) Think very hard about the 3D maze between their first and second attempts at getting through it c) Think of something entirely different between their first and second attempts at getting through the 3D maze d) Take a nap and dream about the 3D maze between the first and second attempt at getting through it e) Try harder the second time around

Exercise 2. Reading comprehension. Read "The Story Behind Dreams" in the lesson material (10 paragraphs). Then answer.

1. PART A: Which statement best expresses the central idea of the text? a) People have different dreams for different reasons, making it difficult for scientists to answer the question "why do humans dream?" b) Most of the theories that scientists have about dreams show their benefits; however, there are no concrete conclusions for why humans dream. c) Scientists struggle to understand why people dream as there is currently no way to see what goes on in the brain when someone sleeps. d) Since humans are the only creatures that dream, scientists believe that dreaming is an important part of humans' advanced intelligence.
2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A? a) "You turn to the student next to you for help and realize it's your best friend who moved away in second grade. Then, you wake up. You were dreaming." (Paragraph 1) b) "Dreams can be exciting or terrifying. Often, they are complicated and confusing. And for much of human history, we've tried to make sense of them." (Paragraph 2) c) "The theory states the stories are formed only as we try to make sense our dreams' confusing twists and turns in the conscious state." (Paragraph 6) d) "Regardless of why we dream, scientists agree that dreams can have many benefits. One group of scientists proved that dreams could help people solve complex problems." (Paragraph 7)
3. What is the author's main purpose in the text? a) to explore the different theories that attempt to explain why humans dream b) to prove the benefits of searching for meaning in your dreams c) to criticize scientists for how little they know about why humans dream d) to support the idea that dreams prepare humans for problems in the real world
4. How does the author's discussion of Paul McCartney and René Descartes contribute to the development of ideas in the text (Paragraphs 8-9)? a) It shows how new and influential ideas can come from dreams. b) It proves that intelligent people tend to have more complex dreams. c) It demonstrates the importance of trying to understand our dreams. d) It supports the theory that your brain is organizing information as you sleep.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me five questions about the talk 'Why Do We Dream?'. Correct my verb tenses."
- "I will explain three theories of dreaming in my own words, with 'The theory holds that ...' or 'Scientists believe that ...'. Tell me if my explanation is accurate and if my grammar is correct."
- "Ask me the five discussion questions about dreams one by one. After each answer, ask me one follow-up question."

- "Check my answers to Exercise 2. Then ask me why two of the wrong options are wrong."

Read aloud

1. Mesopotamian kings recorded /ɪd/ and interpreted /ɪd/ their dreams on wax tablets.
2. In the early 1900s, Sigmund Freud proposed /d/ that dreams have symbolic meanings.
3. Subjects were much better at getting through a complex 3-D maze if they had napped /t/ and dreamed /d/ of the maze.
4. Scientists in Germany proved /d/ this when they studied /d/ the electrical signals in the brains of sleeping mice.
5. He woke up thinking of the tune, and then immediately rushed /t/ to the piano.
6. When he woke up, he recalled /d/ from his dreams the scientific method.
7. Word stress: sub·CON·scious, PROPH·e·cy, hip·po·CAM·pus, de·FIN·i·tive, con·SOL·i·date, re·HEAR·sal, in·spi·RA·tion.

Writing task

Discussion post. Write a post of 150 to 200 words that answers these five questions:

- Do you remember your dreams?
- What languages are your dreams in?
- Do you have recurring dreams? In other words, do you frequently dream about the same topic?
- Do you think dreams have meanings? Why or why not?
- Why do you think people dream?

In your answer to the last question, report at least one theory from the talk or the reading (for example: "The threat simulation theory holds that ..."), and say if you agree.

Then ask your tutor: "Write two short posts as two classmates who answered the same questions." Reply to each post in 2-3 sentences: point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give your opinion on one of their points.

Checklist:

- I answered all five questions.
- I used the simple present for habits and opinions (I often dream in ...).
- I used the simple past for one dream that I remember (Last week I dreamed ...).
- I reported a theory correctly: theory + holds/proposes/states that + subject + verb.
- I used "might" or "could" for ideas that are not proven.
- Every sentence has a subject and a verb.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "Why Do We Dream?" by Amy Adkins (TED-Ed): https://www.ted.com/talks/amy_adkins_why_do_we_dream?language=en

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. b) False (book). The talk says: "we still don't have any definite answers, but we have some interesting theories."
2. c) Sigmund Freud (book).
3. a) Keep your brain active when sensory input is low (book). When "external input falls below a certain level", the brain makes data "so it doesn't completely shut down". (The talk calls it the "continual activation theory".)
4. b) Primitive Instinct Rehearsal Theory (book).
5. d) (book). In the 2010 study, people who napped and dreamed of the maze were up to ten times better.

Exercise 2

1. b) (book). The text presents many theories and benefits, and paragraph 10 says that a lot of it "is just theorizing". Option d) is false: paragraph 3 says that humans aren't the only animals who dream.
2. d) (book). It joins both halves of the Part A answer: "regardless of why we dream" (no conclusion) and "many benefits".
3. a) (book).
4. a) (book). The song "Yesterday" and the scientific method are new ideas that came from dreams.

My notes